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GORDON-CONWELL THEOLOGICAL SEMINARY

URBAN THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION FOR CHURCH LEADERSHIP IN THE CITY OF LOWELL, MASSACHUSETTS

SUBMITTED TO:

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APRIL 19, 2003

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INTRODUCTION

Traditional theological education is increasingly losing its relevancy; therefore, a more contextualized approach is needed. The present work is a proposal made to Gordon-Conwell's Center for Urban Ministerial Education program (CUME) in order to establish an urban theological education program for church leadership in the city of Lowell, Massachusetts. The proposal begins with an analysis of the targeted community followed by an analysis of CUME. It then offers two models to evaluate and use as guides in this endeavor. A brief survey of theological education in general is then offered followed by a small section on globalization, and then a lengthy explication of urban theological education is rendered. This section includes discussions of constituency, contextualization, and curriculum. The intention of this proposal is to convince the reader that the realization of this program could prove to be significantly instrumental in participating in the earthly expansion of the reign of God.

COMMUNITY ANALYSIS

The following analysis is the result of a community study of the Highland Neighborhood in Lowell, Massachusetts. On the North of the neighborhood is the Merrimack River and Middlesex Street runs along side it. A railroad also runs along the river. On the west side, Wood Street crosses Middlesex Street heading south. It passes the Middlesex Plaza not too far from Lowell University. On the South, Wood Street runs into Westford Street and Westford Street travels to the east side and runs into route 3A. Florence Street hugs the eastern border and Wedge Street borders the southern part of the community.

The total population of the community was 5,394 in 1990. By the year 2000, 5,857 was

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the population rendering an increase of 463.[1] According to the US Census Bureau, the racial/ethnic breakdown is as follows:

race	**percentage 1990**	**percentage 2000**
white	76.4	58.9
black	5.2	4.1
Asian	13.9	29.5
other	4.5	7.5

Note the drastic decrease in the white population from 1990 to 2000 and the immense increase of the Asian population. There are slightly more men than women in this community since 1990 when there were slightly more females. However, this appears to be true only for the Asian community.[2] But note that it evens out above age 18. This begins to reflect the national average with 49.1 males and 50.9 females.[3]

According to the US Census Bureau the age categories compared to the national statistics are as follows:

age	**community**	**nation**
0-4	8.3	6.8
5-9	6.1	7.3
10-14	5.5	7.3
15-44	56.4	44.1
45-64	16.0	22.0
65+	7.7	12.4

Note that the population is significantly higher between the ages 0-4 and 14-44 than the national percentage. Statistics taken from the MISER Institute indicate the following marital status of the community:

now married (except single): 41.06
single
never married: 23.32

[1] US Census Bureau
[2] US Census Bureau and MISER Institute
[3] *Ibid.*

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separated:	3.14
divorced:	6.79
widowed:	3.91

23.7 percent of married couples have children while 19.2 percent do not have children. 5.7 percent single female households have children and 2.3 percent of single male households have children. The average household size is 3.06 percent which has increased since 1990 when it was 2.54. The Lowell city average is 2.67 percent, which is close to the national average at 2.59.[4] Only 12.2 percent of all the housing units in the community are owner occupied, and 79.4 percent of the housing units are low income. The medial housing value for the community is $131,800.00, which is a decrease from 1990 when it was $134,400.[5] Only 25.7 percent of persons twenty-five years and older have completed high school. This is a sharp contrast with the national average at 84.1 percent.[6] In 1990 the median income was $34,637.00, but has increased to $46,929.00 in 2000. The increase is higher than the national average at $43,848.00; however, the median income of the Lowell metropolitan area is $32,306.00.[7] 83 percent of the community's labor force is blue collar workers: factories, retail, trade, repair, craft. The 13.6 percent unemployment rate in 1990 dropped to 6.4 percent in 2000.[8]

Recreational facilities and activities of the community include YMCA, health clubs, museums, theaters, and a national park. Community events include the Angkor Dance Troupe, the Annual Southeast Asian Water Festival, Cambodian New Year, and the Cambodian Holocaust Memorial. Community organizations, clubs, social, political, educational groups, and social service agencies include Cambodian American League of Lowell (CALL), Cambodian Mutual Assistance League (CMAA), Career Center of Lowell, The Child Care Circuit, the city

[4] US Census Bureau and MISER Institute
[5] US Census Bureau
[6] US Census Bureau
[7] US Census Bureau
[8] US Census Bureau and MISER Institute

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of Lowell's Pollard Library, Community Teamwork Inc., Convention and Visitors Bureau, Greater Lowell Chamber of Commerce, Lower Highlands Neighborhood Association, American-Southeast Asian Literacy and Education Counseling Inc.

A ministry in the Lower Highlands Neighborhood of Lowell, MA, will deal with a variety of issues and a variety of people but mostly Cambodian immigrants. In researching this community I interviewed six people who live in the community: Borann Som, Rom Rhorn, Hung Pham, Vesna Nuon, Martha Ginsburg, and Jane Ginsburg. Martha and Jane Ginsburg are Anglo-Americans. All the rest are Cambodian immigrants. The Cambodians shared similar concerns for the community. They have resided in the United States for less than twenty years except for Vesna who has been in the country for just twenty years. The concerns of the Cambodian community are immigration and deportation issues, employment and low paying jobs, transportation and commuting problems. There is a language and cultural barrier, intergenerational conflicts, educational issues, prejudice, and problems with gambling. I attempted to make contact with Jane Ginsburg, who is a community leader of the Lower Highlands Neighborhood Group, but she was not home so I spoke with her mother who is an Irish American. She was very defensive at first and refused to speak with me because she thought I was a newspaper reporter. She said that some reporters have attacked her daughter's work with the community in the past. However, when I told her that I was a seminary student, she said, "Oh, that's different. I've been a Baptist for fifty years."

Martha is sixty years old so her perspective is a little different from the others I spoke with. She complained about noise pollution and the Asian neighbors cooking things outside that did not smell like food to her. She said the Asian community was antisocial and did not want to learn the English language. She said that the local politicians did not want to help with her

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community and part of the problem is that only one fourth of Lowell's population even bothered to vote. She said that the educational budget in Lowell has been cut drastically and that it was a problem, especially for the Asian community. She also complained of the high housing costs. In parting she told me to keep my sermons short and sweet and not to ask for money and the Lord would bless me. Later on, I finally had the opportunity to speak with her daughter, Jane Ginsburg. She complained of problems with parking, graffiti, prostitutes, drug pushers and users, and gang activity (mostly Hispanic & Asian). As a community leader, she decried the current political apathy among both city officials and members of the community. Her Christian faith appeared to be nominal.

Unlike other Cambodians I spoke with, Vesna Nuon was highly educated. He was the former assistant district attorney for the city of Lowell. He had recently lost the election for member of the school committee.[9] This was a disappointment to him. In his mind, the educational problem was the all-important issue for the Cambodians of the community. There is a problem with the Cambodian youths dropping out of school. He attributes this to the existing culture barrier. When I asked him about prejudice, he was reluctant to talk about it. His voice became tense as he said, "Yes, there is prejudice, but we are not going to let that stop us! We are going forward!" He believes that if the parents were more involved with their children's schooling it would make a big difference. Vesna explained how the Buddhist monks were helping with the youth, both to deter them from crime and to preserve their culture, but that also much of the youth was too Americanized to relate to them. He also mentioned that Big Brother, Big Sister, and an organization called "Youth Tech" were also playing a positive role with the youth. Vesna further described the intergenerational conflicts that occur. Older Cambodians are offended when the younger Cambodians do not honor them by bowing--a custom that is rooted

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in their culture. Older Cambodians have a difficult time accepting the American concept of dating and courtship. The youth appear to be caught in the middle of two worlds. The other Cambodians interviewed seemed to be more concerned with employment and better paying jobs. Hung Pham emphasized the transportation problem and Rom Rhorn was concerned about immigration.

In more than forty percent of Lowell households, English is not the primary language. This is likely a reflection of the communication problem.[10] Part of the problem with the political process is that many Cambodians cannot vote because they are not citizens, and many that arecitizns do not understand or do not care about the election process. The Ethnic Coalition in Lowell has been struggling with elected officials to make elections fairer, but have encountered opposition by politicians.[11] Although the overall crime rate has dropped in Lowell, aggravated assaults have increased. The Lowell police attribute this to gang violence. Police officials say that continued police-sponsored community outreach programs that have helped a great deal in the Lower Highlands Neighborhood will eventually resolve the problem. But more people from the community need to get involved[12]. Vesna Nuon does not believe the gang problem is a major concern because the gangs are not organized. They are sporadic assemblies of the youth "looking for something to do." Vesna also played down the immigration problem. According to the Lowell Sun, drug activity is also a big problem.[13]

With a 6.79 percent divorce rate and 3.14 percent of spouses separated, family issues need to be addressed in the community. Widows constitute 3.91 percent of the community population and so their care should be looked into. Ministry to single parents would be

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[9] see Lowell Sun 11/5/03
[10] Lowell Sun 10/10/03
[11] Lowell Sun 10/10/03
[12] Lowell Sun 7/31/03

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appropriate since they make up eight percent of the population. Only 12.2 percent of the housing units are owner occupied. Perhaps with more education in this area and with the aid of government sponsored programs this could change, even though Martha Ginsburg said that the prices are just too high. The statistics on education correspond with the statements of those interviewed. Only 25.7 percent of the people are high school graduates. In addition to the above social problems mentioned, a local journal adds alcoholism, social isolation, and social and economic violence.[14]

There are about five churches in the community. Calvary Baptist has a congregation of fifty members of which twenty-five are Asian, sixteen Caucasian, one Panama, one Alaskan, one African, one Chinese. Community Christian Fellowship has a congregation of approximately 300 members. Notre Dame Delourdes Catholic church has a congregation of approximately 300 people mostly in the forty and fifties age group. Harbor of Hope Christian church is an evangelical church with about 150 members. This is a young church with a young congregation. It consists mostly of couples in their twenties and thirties. There are 122 adults and twenty-nine children. There is also St. George Greek Orthodox church on Princeton Boulevard.

ANALYSIS OF ORGANIZATION

Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary located at 130 Essex Street, South Hamilton, Massachusetts 01982 was formed from the merging of two prominent theological institutions which had been very instrumental in the training of evangelical leaders for many areas of ministry. In 1884, the well-known Rev. Russell Conwell established the Conwell School of Theology in Philadelphia. This school later evolved into Temple University. A. J. Gordon

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[13] Lowell Sun 10/14/03

[14] *Commonwealth*. vol. 72, summer 2002

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established the Boston Missionary Training School at Boston, Massachusetts in 1889. Rev. Gordon was passionate for foreign missions and urban ministry in New England, and this school reflected that concern. The school's name was changed to Gordon College and Divinity School after Rev. Gordon's death. In 1951 the school moved to Wenham, Massachusetts. The merging of Gordon Divinity School and the Conwell School of Theology was effected in 1969 by the efforts of J. Howard Pew, Harold J. Ockenga, and Billy Graham. The Divinity School separated from the College at this time. And so Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary was born with Dr. Ockenga as its first president, who retired in 1979. Dr. Robert E. Cooley succeeded him in 1981. The third and current president of the seminary, Walter C. Kaiser, was inaugurated in 1997. The campus in South Hamilton, MA was purchased in the fall of 1970.

After the merging of 1969, the historical commitments of both prior schools to urban ministry was still in the consciousness of the seminary due to the presence of people like Dr. Stephen C. Mott. In 1969 while the merge was taking place, Dr. Douglas Hall, Executive Director of the Emmanuel Gospel Center in Boston, had proposed to Gordon-Conwell a three-pronged urban ministry program.[15] There was no official response to his proposal, but in 1973, Dr. Hall along with Dr. Stephen Mott began to team-teach inner city ministry courses at Emmanuel Gospel Center for traditional seminary students under the auspices of the seminary. In addition to Dr. Mott and Dr. Hall with his wife Dr. Judy Hall, Dean Borgman also traveled from the South Hamilton campus to teach in the city. This program became known as the Urban Middler Year Program and was originally instituted so that the North Shore students could get training in urban ministry. It was the urban ministry program before Gordon-Conwell's *Center for Urban Ministerial Education* program (CUME). As Gordon-Conwell's Urban Studies

[15] (1) an urban training program for traditional seminary students; (2) a training program for bivocational leaders of churches; (3) a research component to inform both of these programs.

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Committee began to review the urban ministry program in 1975 intending to initiate an urban ministry extension school in Boston by 1976, a young Hispanic Pentecostal who was engaged in doctrinal studies at Boston University arrived on the scene. His name was Eldin Villafane from New York City. He was well educated and had acquired quality ministry experience in the largest Hispanic church in the nation: Iglesa Cristiana Juan 3:16.

Having lighted upon Emmanuel Gospel Center's multilingual book store and having left his card there, one thing led to another and he met with Dr.'s Hall, Mott, and Borgman. This led to Gordon-Conwell's hiring of Mr. Villafane as an assistant professor, Registrar of Extension Education, and Field Coordinator of the Urban Studies Program.[16] And so CUME was born in 1976. Right from the start Dr. Villafane began teaching four to five courses and basically running the whole school by himself. Classes were held at the historic Martin Luther King, Jr. House of Twelfth Baptist Church, where the CUME office was also located. There were also courses held at Emmanuel Gospel Center, and by 1978 courses were also held at the Greater Lawrence Ecumenical Area Ministry (GLEAM) in Lawrence, MA. As CUME developed and grew, more locations were added for class sites.

One of the difficult tasks for the program was to ascertain and maintain qualified professors. In addressing this problem, Dr. Villafane persuaded well-known teachers from outside Boston to teach weekend seminar series held once a month. George W. Webber of New York Theological Seminary (NYTS) implies that without Dr. Villafane, there might not be a CUME.[17] But Dr. Villafane indicates that he could not have done it without the support of Gordon-Conwell's president, Dr. Harold J. Ockenga.[18] Subsequently, Lloya Kalland and Garth

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[16] Jackson, Bruce Wilmer. *TOWARD A CONTEXTUALIZED URBAN THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION: THE CENTER FOR URBAN MINISTERIAL EDUCATION--AN HISTORICAL AND ANALYTICAL CASE STUDY*. Ann Arbor, MI 48103: UMI company 1995, p. 138

[17] Jackson, Bruce W. *TOWARD A CONTEXTUALIZED URBAN THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION: AN HISTORICAL AND ANALYTICAL CASE STUDY*. Ann Arbor, MI 48103: UMI Company 1995, page 173.

[18] *Ibid*. page 174.

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Rossell played significant roles in the earlier stages of CUME. Two key figures within the city of Boston were crucial to CUME's founding and development: Dr. Michael E. Haynes, senior minister of Twelfth Baptist Church (TBC) and the afore mentioned Dr. Douglas Hall, Executive Director of Emmanuel Gospel Center.

The years following 1982 were full of rejoicing from the past success, but with that success came greater challenges. As CUME became more complex and the student population increased, so increased financial demands, staff and faculty necessities, and the parent campus's desire to gain more control. There was also a concern for maintaining accreditation. During this time, in addition to English and Spanish, classes in Creole French and Portuguese were offered at CUME. This met some resistance from the parent seminary, but Dr. Villafane managed to persuade it of the necessity. Without a badly needed secretary, greater staff demands, and the fact that the parent seminary instituted a moratorium on hiring more staff due to a budget crunch, things became all the more difficult for CUME. This was partially alleviated by a unique agreement with Emmanuel Gospel Center. As a result of this arrangement, Bruce Jackson was hired and CUME attained a valuable staff member.

A shift in administrative policy occurred during this era that greatly upset Dr. Villafane. Instead of reporting to the Academic Dean, he now was instructed to report to the Director of Continuing and Extension Education. Dr. Villafane thought this was detrimental to CUME and he vehemently protested it. In addition to reporting to his new superior, Dr. Villafane continued to send monthly reports to the Academic Dean and the President of the seminary. Evidently, the seminary "caught the drift" and in the following year placed CUME back under the direct supervision of the Dean.

1990 was a major transition year for CUME. The staff of CUME moved into its own

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building at 363 South Huntington Avenue in Boston. Dr. Villafane stepped down from being CUME's founding director to become Gordon-Conwell's Associate Dean for Urban and Multicultural Affairs. Efrain Agosto became the new Director of CUME. Bruce Jackson became the Associate Director. Ira V. Frazier, who was hired in 1989, began the mentored ministry program at CUME. There was also a change in curriculum at this time that reflected the academy more than the contextualized approach of previous years.

At the beginning of the twenty-first century, CUME once again is experiencing growing pains. Its student population has increased and it is in the process of searching for a larger building. Under the leadership of Dr. Alvin Padilla, the current dean of CUME, and with the full support of the seminary stemming from the original vision of the two merging schools which gave birth to it still alive, CUME will continue to train urban leaders in our cities making a major impact for the cause of Christ until he returns to bring the final semester to a close.

MODELS

Visions For Springfield

> "Where there is no vision, the people are unrestrained,
> but happy is he who keeps the law."[19]

Visions for Springfield (VFS) is a faith-based nonprofit organization established "to understand and nurture the vitality of the church in the context of the broader urban community of Springfield, Massachusetts."[20] It all began on July 28 1998 when Dr.'s Douglas and Judy Hall of Emanuel Gospel Center in Boston were invited to come to Springfield in order to conduct a hexagon study around the question, "What is your vision for Springfield?" Donna Calawa, the organization's founder, sent out letters to area churches to invite them to the meeting. About

[19] Prov. 29:18, NASB

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forty to fifty Christians from churches and parachurch organizations came together for the meeting. Fifty visions emerged out of this meeting. These visions were consolidated under three main headings: evangelism, theological education, research and communication.

At a later date, Donna traveled to Emmanuel Gospel Center in Boston where the Halls, Dale Atlas, and Donna worked together on the steps necessary to fulfill these visions. This resulted in a group of Anglo male pastors from the Springfield area and Donna, an urban missionary, initiating the work toward the fulfillment of these visions through the establishment of "Visions For Springfield." This ministry began with the ultimate goal of starting an urban ministry resource center in Springfield.

During the first three years a crisis regarding the leadership team occurred. One by one, members of the team began to drop out for various reasons. An African-American pastor joined the team but left after a year. These developments drove Donna to diligently seek the Lord's guidance in the area of leadership. She discerned that she was depending on the pastors more than on God. The Lord moved in a dramatic way by bringing a leadership team of six people who were committed to the shalom of the city. The new leadership team was composed of three male pastors and three women, all involved in urban ministry. Two of the pastoral staff were Afro-Americans and the women were Afro-American, Hispanic, and Anglo. The team continues to meet periodically, even though the Halls had suggested that the staff meetings occur more regularly. The staff meets at different places: churches, parachurch organizations, restaurants, and homes.

The entire leadership team is trained in urban ministry. Some received their training through CUME, others through their respective denominations. Among the faith community, about 145 students have taken CUME courses. This number reflects the fact that some of the

[20] Visions For Springfield Statement of Purpose. See appendix.

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same students have taken more that one course. Visions For Springfield and CUME have made inroads to the Afro-American community. Making inroads to the Hispanic community has been much more difficult. Many of the Hispanic churches are storefronts and not listed. Communication with the Spanish community has proved to be a barrier even though there is a Hispanic woman on VFS's and CUME's leadership team. A minister from the Hispanic community also works to promote CUME classes in Spanish in his church and other churches, but he has had limited success. VFS and CUME need to get more involved with the Hispanic community. Donna hopes that the church/parachurch directory VFS is working on will help alleviate this problem.

Donna has begun some limited involvement in the *Pastoral Commission on Aids and Addiction in Springfield* because City Hall and her pastor requested more information on these problems and how they affect the city. She intends to do things God's way in God's time, with God's resources while not expecting everything to go exactly as planned. She is also currently working to attain a 501 (c) (3). She has already received a matching grant, and also a direct grant for $3000.00 toward the development of *The Springfield Pictorial Christian Church Resource and Network Guide*.

Hindrances and barriers to evangelism in Springfield are racism (churches will not work together), lack of prayer (church community in general), and a lack of effective discipleship. Douglas Hall has recommended that for evangelism to flourish, the obstacles must be removed. Therefore, Donna has become involved with the Springfield Christian Leadership Council (SCLC) for Racial Reconciliation. Currently this ministry continues to work on ways to help fight systemic racism. The establishment of the CUME program in Springfield has helped to work on the "lack of effective discipleship" barrier to evangelism. Donna is personally working

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on the "lack of prayer" problem and has done some email networking, but she is still seeking ways to more concretely promote prayer in the churches of Springfield.

Reflection

Donna's discernment that she was depending too much on the pastors and not enough on God is a caveat for any ministry. The Lord brought to Donna people committed to the shalom of the city after she had diligently sought the Lord. This is essential for any urban ministry including the one contained in this proposal. The staff of VFS meets at different places: churches, parachurch organizations, restaurants, and homes. This is in line with the "pilgrim model" that embraces the plan set down in this paper. Donna intends to do things God's way, in God's time, with God's resources while not expecting everything to go exactly as planned. This is very important and worthy of emulation, especially the part about "not expecting everything to go exactly as planned." This leaves room for the leading of the Spirit. The application for a 501 (c) (3) and other grants is also a good idea. The present work will also embrace Donna's example of working "with" the community.[21] Dr. Hall's admonishment to remove obstacles should caution one to be sensitive to the hindrances of the ministry.

VFS's statement of purpose states, "The church is God's chosen instrument to bring his life and presence into our communities, and is God's appointed means of spreading the Gospel of Jesus Christ." This concept underlies the following project. The focus of the suggested ministry will mimic VFS's *goal of ministry*: "Vital churches are characterized by obedience to God's purpose, by service to the world as servants and witnesses, by working to extend God's reign and build up the body of Christ, and by their desire to glorify the Name of Jesus." This proposal is also in agreement with VFS's dependence on the Lord's leading and timing in making decisions,

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the seeking of long term results, building relations with the community, focus on the entire kingdom of God, and the utilization of resources that the Lord provides.

New York Theological Seminary

> "Forget the former things: do not dwell on the past. See, I am doing a new thing! Now it springs up; do you not perceive it? I am making a way in the desert and streams in the wasteland."[22]

After nine years of struggling, New York Theological Seminary (NYTS) found itself on the verge of bankruptcy and was uncertain about its future. In a last ditch effort to save the institution, George W. (Bill) Webber was employed as the CEO in 1969. When Bill Webber came to the seminary in its desperate condition, he found that the situation afforded him freedom to experiment with theological education in a way that no other seminary would risk. This is the value of hitting rock bottom with nothing left to lose. Bill reasoned that the situation could not possibly get any worse. He went to work dismantling the traditional patterns of theological education and followed a path of reform not guided by a planned vision but the present crisis determined the course of events. This is the story of New York Theological Seminary.

George William Webber

Webber's consciousness was aroused to urban ministry in 1946 while he was a student at Union Seminary in New York city. A fellow student, Don Benedict, expressed his grief to Bill concerning the apathy and neglect of inner-city ministry by the denominations reflected in the other seminary students. While Bill was supervising students who worked in the East Harlem Protestant Parish, he began to be afflicted with the nagging question: "How does one equip men

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[21] See the *Action* section in VFS's statement of purpose in the appendix.

[22] Isa. 43:18-19, NIV

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and women for urban ministry, and what role can the seminary play in that undertaking?"[23] In 1957, Bill and his wife moved into a low income public housing project in East Harlem.

Bill was dean of students, and a teacher at Union Seminary while he continued his work at East Harlem Protestant Parish (EHPP), but his base was now in the inner city by virtue of his residence there. In 1966, Bill was asked to organize the *Metropolitan Urban Service Training Program* (MUST). Accepting this challenge, Bill found himself involved in continuing education. This was good preparation for Bill's future experience at NYTS. Bill recounts the reason for the emergence of MUST: "The impetus for MUST grew out of the awareness that mainline churches, for all the interest in urban ministry during the ten-year period after 1995, had not made much of an impact."[24] MUST made possible on-the-job training. During Bill's twenty year experience prior to his placement at NYTS, there were three integral encounters that helped shape him for his future ministry. The first was his involvement in the development of the Metropolitan intern program initiated in 1964. This was a year-long program directed at students in the year between college and seminary that offered experience in relating to the life of the city. This program emerged during the unsettling years of the Vietnam war when the enrollment of seminaries was very high. Authentic personhood according to Ephesians 4 played a key role in the program. The importance of this fact is conveyed by Bill Webber's statement, "Laity seem desperately eager to have clergy with a clear sense of their own identity who are able to relate to them as authentic human beings."[25]

A second experience revolved around the mandate to function as a professional school. Webber felt that it was time to focus more on the practical disciplines of ministry rather than the traditional emphasis on the academic encyclopedia. At a conference held at Andover Newton

[23] Webber, George William. *Led By The Spirit*. New York: New Pilgrim Press 1990, p. 2.
[24] Webber, George William. *Ibid*. p. 4

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Theological school, Bill's criticisms were met with strong words from one of the attending professors:

> "You've got no business to be as harsh in your critique of the patterns of the church until you address one significant problem. From my point of view,' he said, 'the clergy have simply not been trained in the skills and competency required for effective ministry. And until we have competent clergy you have no business making these judgments about the life of the church. Who knows what might be possible were the leaders of congregations able teachers, community analysts equipped with other skills that the kind of missionary church you seek requires?"[26]

This incident had a significant impact on Bill Webber. The third occurrence was in 1966 when the American Association of Theological Schools (AATS) invoked a group of eight seminary faculty to construct a curriculum as if anything they came up with would be approved. In other words, all restraints were removed. The curriculum was published in the summer 1968 issue of *Theological Education*, entitled, "The Curriculum for the Seventies." This curriculum gave birth to the concept of "doing theology." They referred to this model as action/reflection. It employed the method of integrating theory with practice, faith with life. *Praxis* is the term used by liberation theologians. Bill Webber was greatly impressed by this curriculum.

Brief History of New York Theological Seminary

In the very beginning, it was Wilbert Webster White who founded the Bible Teacher's College in Montclair, New Jersey in 1900. It was White's intention to make sure that the Bible took center stage in the curriculum of the school he fixed to establish. He was also determined that his students would be well versed in Scripture. Evidently this goal was achieved. In 1902, the school was moved to New York City and renamed the Bible Teacher's Training School. It took on the name, The Bible Seminary in New York in 1921, and renamed New York

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[25] *Ibid.* p. 6

[26] Webber, George William. *Ibid.* p. 7

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Theological Seminary (NYTS) in 1965. The seminary was laity-controlled and completely nondenominational. The charter mandated sixty percent of the trustees be laity, and seven was the maximum number allowed from a particular denomination.[27] By the time of the Great Depression, financial struggles could easily be foreseen since Dr. White refused to establish an endowment, and there was understandably no denominational support, nor support from other educational institutions. By 1968, the seminary was on the verge of financial collapse, but a small group of dedicated trustees were determined to keep the sinking ship afloat. This scene set the stage for the arrival of Bill Webber.

From the beginning, NYTS provided a committed theological education to both men and women, and all races and ethnic groups as well as all denominations. In the beginning of the 1970's the seminary sold its campus and moved to a more cost-effective location. The academic focus shifted at this point, which centered on adult theological education. In the 1980's, NYTS initiated a graduate level theological studies program at Sing Sing prison. In the 1990's a modification in the curriculum occurred that would better prepare churches address the needs of urban areas by appropriating sociological analysis and theory. The seminary moved to a section in New York city called Morningside Heights in 2002 where it developed partnerships with the Riverside church and Union Theological Seminary. With its multicultural, multilingual student population and its flexible planning schedule, NYTS is now the largest accredited Christian seminary in New York State.

Troubles and Triumphs

The academic year of 1968-1969 began with a grim outlook for the future of New York Theological Seminary. At this time the seminary owned a large twelve-story building in the heart of New York city. However, the majority of the building was unused. The dormitory was

[27] There were thirty-six trustees.

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only partially occupied. Some of the space was rented out to individuals who worked in the city. As indicated above, finances were the pressing issue at the beginning of the semester. The projected deficit for the year was $100,000.00. In spite of this, it appears that God had raised up a small group of trustees who demonstrated the divine gift of faith. They were determined to keep the seminary alive.

They concluded that the solution to the problem was to ascertain a new president. As candidates were consulted, none were willing to accept the position while the institution had such a bleak future. The trustees sought out Bill Webber, who was not really interested in the position. He had procured tenure with a satisfying position at Union Theological Seminary, and he was comfortable at the same time continuing his work with MUST. Shortly after discussing the position with the trustees of NYTS, they notified Bill informing him that he had been elected as the president. Bill refused the position, but empathizing with their grief and anxiety, he agreed to be a consultant for them until they found a president.

After Bill had carefully evaluated the situation, his recommendation was that the trustees make preparations to terminate the institution. Theological education at this time faced a transition in its constituency. There were many second career students enrolling in seminaries as well as an increase in women students. This was occurring contemporaneously with, and most likely galvanized by the Civil Rights movement and the Vietnam War. Theological education nation wide was reexamining issues of financing and the role of trustees. Traditional patterns of teaching and curriculum were also being questioned. With the encouragement of the staff of MUST to seize the opportunity for change in theological education, and the persuasion of some determined trustees, Bill decided to accept the position, and so became president on March 15, 1969.

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Finances, curriculum development, and recruitment were the foremost issues that the new president and his staff were confronted with. These problems were interrelated. Bill began with curriculum development. The curriculum developed was adapted from the AATS's "Curriculum for the Seventies," referred to above. The intention of the curriculum is reflected in the goal statement produced by the planning committee:

> "The purpose of New York Theological Seminary is to provide a community of learning in an urban setting, rooted in biblical encounter and commitment to Christ, which enables men and women to discover, and become equipped for, Christian living and mission in the contemporary world."[28]

The programs were expanded in order to attract a new constituency. Students were attracted to the focus on teaching the student rather than imposing a discipline. So in this way, reforming the curriculum also helped the recruitment problem. In addition, Bill sent letters to all the relevant people he knew across the country requesting their support and to encourage potential students to embark on this new experimental, theological enterprise. In June of 1968, it became evident that the financial situation would not allow the seminary to remain open. Bill counseled the trustees to begin drawing up the plans to close the school. At the beginning of the school year, an announcement was made to faculty and students that the seminary would close unless two conditions were met: (1) an impressive curriculum was to be developed; (2) the seminary had to attain financial security.

The seminary borrowed $125,000.00 from the Broadway United Church of Christ at market rates. Bill managed to ascertain a grant of $30,000.00 from the Charles C. Merrill Trust. The salary of the president was lowered and that of the faculty was raised. This boosted the morale of the faculty. The faculty also went on a retreat with a professional consultant which

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proved to be quite beneficial and highlighted the importance of human relationships.

The class enrolling in 1969 was larger that it had been in many years. The new curriculum was attractive to the current constituency. It was exciting for the students but frustrating for the faculty. In March, the decision came down to terminate the entire faculty for financial reasons. A new streamlined faculty was attained, which Bill identified as administrator-teacher-church person. As can be derived from the title it was a multipurpose position. The seminary was no longer a residential seminary. The dormitory was rented out, and the unused office space was rented to nonprofit organizations. The building began to generate up to $50,000.00 a year over and above overhead. There were now no full-time salaries to pay since the teachers received compensation on a piecework type of system. Teachers also performed administrative tasks which minimized administrative costs. The Sealantic Foundation gave a significant grant to the seminary, which had previously been denied. In 1970, the seminary sold some of its property for $235, 000.00. This sale enabled the seminary to pay off its debts. In 1976, the seminary sold its main twelve-story building in an act of desperation for $1000,000.00, whereas it was worth three times that much. In 1977, the administration moved into a building on Forty-ninth Street.

In 1981, Bill embarked on a project that he identified as "the most unconventional idea that had been proposed to the seminary" since he had come.[29] The seminary began an extension school at Sing Sing prison. Initially, the program met some resistance form prison officials, but as Providence would have it, the deputy commissioner, who was in charge of family services in the state prisons, was a NYTS graduate. This grace moved the program into the prison, but further resistance from prison bureaucracy slowed things down. Just when the seminary decided

[28] Webber, George William. *Ibid.* p. 20
[29] Webber, George William. *Ibid.* p. 111

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to abandon the project, everything fell into place. This was the first seminary program that the trustees approved without the finances in hand. In 1995, Bill intended to institute a college-level certificate program using the graduates of the masters degree program for the teachers, but it was decided against because of the competitive mentality that exists in the prison environment.

Reflection

"Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom."[30] Earlier it was noted how Bill Webber pondered the question, "How does one equip men and women for urban ministry and what role can the seminary play in that undertaking?" This is a perennial question that anyone involved in urban theological education must keep before their eyes because the sociological landscape in the city is in a constant state of flux. The reasons that stimulated the establishment for MUST was also previously stated, "The impetus for MUST grew out of the awareness that mainline churches, for all the interest in urban ministry during the ten year period after 1955, had not made much of an impact." Earlier Bill Webber had himself concluded, "I had come to the conclusion, however, that in some significant degree the clergy were not equipped personally and professionally for faithful and effective ministry in the contemporary world."[31] It was this train of thought that moved Bill Webber, led by the Spirit, to accept the foreordained position at NYTS at the most crucial juncture in the history of theological education.

It was the desperate situation of the seminary that granted Bill the freedom to experiment with a constituency focused curriculum and the development or transformation of NYTS to become a "pilgrim seminary" (nonresidential). The leading of the Spirit is also evident in the

[30] 2 Cor. 3:17, NIV
[31] Webber, George William. *Ibid.* p.13

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various stages of the development of the curriculum. Bill writes in regard of this:

> "It seems all too accurate to say that whenever we fashioned a new program that we thought would meet some very important need among clergy and laity in the New York area, and then sought to recruit for it, it almost always failed. Somehow the bright ideas which we dreamed up in the recesses of the seminary didn't take off. The program that had by 1975 become the content of the three rings[32] were for the most part those that came about when a group of persons laid before us very clear needs and demanded that we shape academic programs to meet them. It was more than a little humbling to realize that our own bright ideas didn't work very well, but it was also a source of gratitude to feel that we were being led by the Spirit to discovering new opportunities that we had not dreamed up ourselves."[33]

The key to developing a contextual curriculum is to dialogue with the constituency and make every effort to address the needs that are conveyed. This is probably the single-most important factor that dictated the changes at NYTS. By the leading of the Spirit, NYTS academically speaking, became all things to all people. Annihilating the false dichotomy between theory and practice, and replacing it with an action-reflection model is worthy of emulation. Equally important is the examples of risk-taking, authentic faith, and the leading of the Spirit that Bill, his staff, and even the students displayed. The type of school that NYTS became led to the discovery that there were many people whom God had called to be leaders, but had been shut out and barred by the system. NYTS made a way for both clergy and lay leaders to fulfill their God-ordained call. NYTS trains all the people of God. The hierarchal divisions have been removed. NYTS decided against using graduates as teachers in the prison program. However, this may be instrumental in the current proposal because it may, at first, be difficult to ascertain Asian professors. A compromise could be made by using Asian TA's alongside a qualified professor of another ethnic origin until some Asian scholars are located.

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[32] The three rings refers to the emerging patterns of the curriculum: master of divinity level, continuing education for clergy, and lay education. This later developed into seminary degree level, college program, and certificate program.

[33] *Ibid*. p. 51

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THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION

> "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."[34]

Traditional theological education revolves around the theological encyclopedia: Biblical studies, church history, systematic theology, and practical theology. Because theological institutions have emulated secular academia, a cerebral form of theological education emerged that has produced a dichotomy between theory and practice, faith and concrete experience. Much of current theological education is plagued by individualism and dualism. In addition to the influence of secular society, it is the present author's belief that the Western mindset is particularly susceptible to this compartmentalized mode of reasoning.

People of different cultures have different ways of viewing the world, and consequently develop different ways of reasoning. The language of a particular people will often reflect their mode of thought. Western civilization was primarily founded on Greek thought. This began in about 313 B.C. when Alexander the Great forged his empire, and under the tutelage of Aristotle, intentionally endeavored to Hellenize the world. The ancient Greek language is a static language. It is a language of being.[35] The Greek philosopher, Heraclitus of Ephesus, indicated that everything was in perpetual flux: "Everything changes; war is the father of all things, and a man cannot step into the same river twice."[36] Heraclitus was the exception not the rule. He was the only Greek philosopher of antiquity that held this view. Plato comments on the view of Heraclitus: "The maintenance of the doctrine have as yet no words in which to express

[34] Matt. 28:18-10, NIV
[35] Boman, Thorleif. *Hebrew Thought Compared with Greek*. New York: W- W- Norton & Company 1970, p. 27
[36] *Ibid*. p. 51

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themselves, and must get a new language. I know of no word that will suit them...."[37] Not only does Plato, through the words of Socrates, disagree with Heraclitus, he indicates that the concept is so foreign to Greek thought, the Greek language is not suitable to express it. Plato further writes, "For we say that it 'is' or 'was' or 'will be,' whereas in truth of speech, 'is' alone is the appropriate term."[38]

This line of thinking naturally and inherently developed a conceptual dichotomy between thought and action. This can be demonstrated with the ancient Greek word λόγος. This word was originally derived from the root λεγ-.[39] In ancient Koine Greek, λόγος is often translated "word," but that is not its only meaning, and in fact, that concept is a fairly late development. Originally, λόγος expressed a collection or a counting, which naturally developed into the idea of calculation, account, consideration, thought out, evaluation, reflection, reason, etc.[40] This word articulated the abstract concept of static thought.

Ancient Hebrew thought, however, is in direct contrast to the ancient Greeks. Whereas Greek thought was static, the language of being, Hebrew thought was dynamic, the language of becoming, the language of action or doing.[41] The ancient Hebrew word דָּבָר means both word and deed. It indicates an event,[42] and also a spoken word.[43] But the two meanings are inextricably intertwined. Word and deed form a unity. In Hebrew thought there was no dichotomy between theory and practice, faith and action. The following diagram illustrates the contrast between the two ancient cultures:[44]

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[37] *Ibid*. p. 52

[38] λέγομεν γὰρ δὴ ὡς ἦν ἔστι τε καὶ ἔσται, τῇ δὲ τὸ ἔστι μόνον κατὰ τὸν ἀληθῆ λόγον προσήκει, Timaeus: 37-38

[39] "to gather or arrange": Kittel, Gerhard and Friedrich, Gerhard, ed. *Theological Dictionary Of The New Testament*. Grand Rapids, MI 49503: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company 1985, p. 505

[40] Kittel, Gerhard and Friedrich, Gerhard, ed. *Ibid*. p. 505; Boman, Thorleif. *Ibid*. p.67

[41] Boman, Thorleif. *Ibid*. p.24ff.

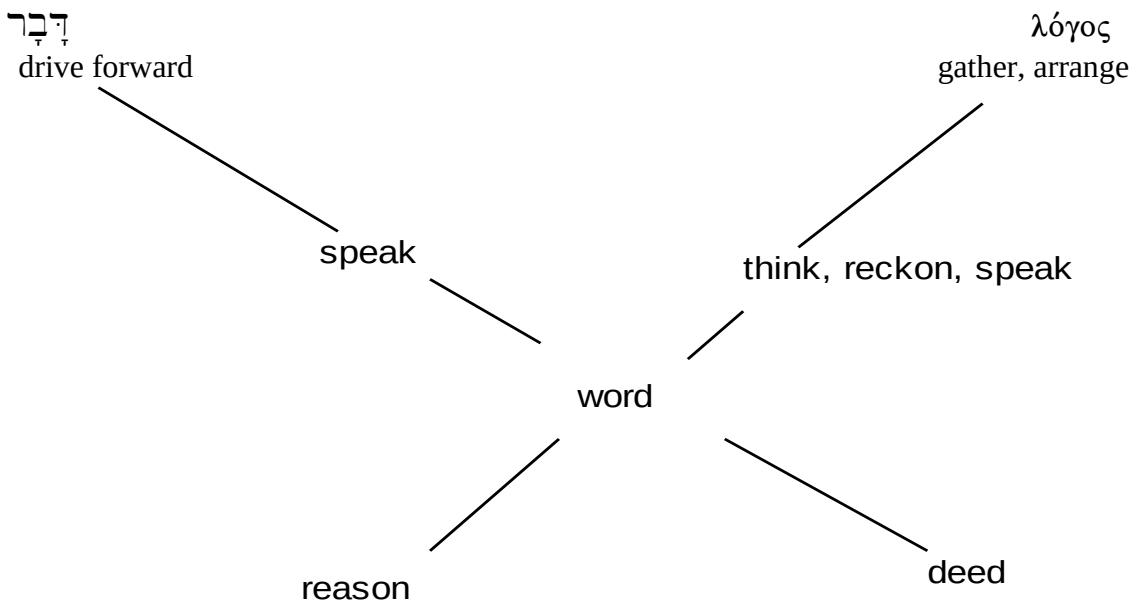
[42] Gen. 22:1

[43] Mic. 4:2

[44] Boman, Thorleif. *Ibid*. p. 68

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Unlike the Greek philosopher, the ancient Hebrews learned by experience, not through philosophical speculation in the abstract. Understanding is acquired by the doing. The Greeks reasoned from the cause to the effect: "I think therefore I am." The thought process of the Hebrews developed from effect to cause: "I am therefore I think."[45] The Hebrew word "to know" (יָדַע) implies knowledge that comes from experience. For a man to *know* his wife is to have sexual relations with her.[46] To *know* God is to experience him.[47] Intelligence in Hebrew thought is not acquired through the empirical method. Intelligence is a gift from God on par with revelation.[48] The essence of intelligence lies in the ability to hear and receive.[49] When Solomon prayed for wisdom, the literal Hebrew is rendered, "Give to your servant a *hearing heart* (שֹׁמֵעַ לֵב) to judge your people...."[50]

[45] Doukhan, Jacques B. *Hebrew For Theologians*. New York: University Press of America Inc. 1993, p. 193
[46] Gen. 4:1, 17; Gen. 19:8, etc.
[47] Ps. 16:11; Jer. 23-24
[48] Ps. 119:125, 144; Job 32:8
[49] Isa. 50:5; Job 12:11; Neh. 8:3; Jer. 6:10; cf. Rev. 2:7; 3:22
[50] 1 Kings 3:9: וְנָתַתָּ לְעַבְדְּךָ לֵב שֹׁמֵעַ לִשְׁפֹּט אֶת־עַמְּךָ

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When Moses gave the divine law to the people of Israel, they responded, " We shall do then we shall hear."[51] In ancient Hebrew thought, learning and experience, theory and practice, faith and action form an indissoluble bond. This Hebrew concept is expressed in the Koine Greek of the NT in such passages as, "He was a prophet, powerful in word and deed before God...."[52] As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead."[53] "...resulting in the obedience of the Gentiles by word and deed."[54] Learning by experience is implicit in the statement: "Although he was a son, he learned obedience from what he suffered...."[55]

Another difference between the two ancient cultures is the concept of human essence. The Greeks believed there was a dichotomy between body and soul.[56] The Hebrews viewed humankind holistically. The human being did not possess a soul, He/she was a soul.[57] Theoretically, one might see the roots of the Fundamentalist/Modernist controversy here. They also viewed humankind as a whole. Adam's sin affected the whole world, Achan's sin affected the entire nation of Israel.[58] The two cultures also viewed time in a very different way. In ancient Greek the tenses of the indicative mood clearly betray a linear, self-centered concept of time, whereas the ancient Hebrews held that time belongs to God, and so no indication of it is reflected in the Hebrew tenses. The Hebrews viewed action as either complete or incomplete. The correlation to chronology was a relative issue and God was at the center of the universe, not humankind as the narcissistic Greeks supposed. The Greeks viewed time as something bad, associated with death, something to despise and fear. Aristotle wrote, "time destroys."[59] The

[51] Ex. 24:7: נַעֲשֶׂה וְנִשְׁמַע
[52] Luke 24:19, NIV
[53] James 2:26, NIV
[54] Rom. 15:18, NASB
[55] Heb. 5:8, NIV
[56] Phaedo: "The body is the prison house of the soul."
[57] Gen. 2:7
[58] Gen.3; Rom. 5:12-14; Josh. 7
[59] Physics iv:12: κατατήκει ὁ χρόνος

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Hebrew viewed time as something good, as a gift of divine providence.[60] Time is equated with the fullness of life,[61] and a person experiences many *times* in his or her life.[62] The Greeks had a cyclical view of history. They esteemed themselves bound in a sphere of repeated events. Time and history, therefore, had no beneficial purpose. It was something that humans were trapped in.[63] Anthony Hoekema writes, "The idea that a history is moving toward divinely established goals, and that the future is to be seen as the fulfillment of promises made in the past, is the unique contribution of the prophets of Israel."[64] This instilled a sense of hope in the Hebrew mind.

A final word on the difference between ancient Greek and Hebrew thought can be easily observed from the writings of the Greek philosophers and a comparison of the OT. Whereas the Greeks came from the perspective of the empirical method, with emphasis on observation and seeing (βλέπω, ὁράω, θεάομαι, θεωρέω), the Hebrews came from the perspective of divine revelation with the emphasis on hearing (אָזַן שָׁמַע). The contrast between Greek and Hebrew thought will be implicitly detected throughout the course of this work.

Robert Banks did a study on ministry formation before the time of Christ. He evaluated theological education in the home of the ancient Israelites, local elders, national leaders, priests, prophets, wisemen, Pharisees, and John the Baptist.[65] He arrived at the following conclusions:[66]

1. The main purpose of associating with a key figure was to collaborate in the active service of God.
2. Associates of this figure attended or accompanied him, in some cases living with or near him.
3. This involved a permanent or temporary break with their normal relationships and surroundings.
4. Learning occurred in diverse settings through participant observation, nonformal discussion, action-reflection, and direct instruction.
5. In some cases successors emerged when the central figures passed on, whereas in others this was a by-product

[60] Ecc. 3:1
[61] Prov. 16:31
[62] Ps. 31:15; Job 24:1
[63] Hoekema, Anthony A. *The Bible And The Future*. Grand Rapids, MI: W. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company 1979, p. 24
[64] Hoekema, Anthony A. *Ibid*. p. 25
[65] Banks, Robert. *Reenvisioning Theological Education*. Grand Rapids, MI: W. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company 1999, p. 83ff.
[66] Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 92-93

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of the association.

In the above Scripture quotation, Jesus commands his disciples (μαθητής) to multiply, that is to make other disciples (μαθητεύω) of all nations. Banks defines the word disciple by stating "...the Greek term *mathetes*, 'disciple,' refers to persons committed to learning the Law through a figure (e.g. Moses: John 9:28) or movement that had significant teachers (e.g. the Pharisees: Matt. 22:15-16)."[67] μαθητής is derived from the word μανθάνω: "to direct one's mind to something, to accustom oneself to something, to experience, to learn, to know, to understand, to learn under instructors, to receive direction form a deity by oracle. [68] μαθητής is defined as one who directs his/her mind to something, a pupil, as one engaged in learning, a learner, a student.[69] In the gospels, the disciples listened to the teaching of Jesus.[70] When Jesus responded to various circumstances and managed different people and events, the disciples were watching.[71] The disciples asked Jesus to explain himself.[72] Jesus also questioned his disciples.[73] Jesus sometimes commanded the disciples.[74] Frequently the disciples participated in Jesus' ministry.[75] Jesus made his disciples by interacting with them and developing a relationship with them in a variety of life experiences and ministry activities. This is the way his disciples would naturally carry out the great commission. It was a theological, educational enterprise. It is significant that Jesus called people to be his disciples,[76] and he is still doing that today. There were no restrictions on people to enter Jesus' kingdom community. People from all walks of life

[67] Banks, Robert. Ibid. p.90
[68] Kittel, Gerhard and Friedrich, Gerhard, Ed. *Ibid*. p. 552
[69] *Ibid*. p. 555
[70] Matt. 10:23; 16:24; 20:26; Mk. 3:9; 4:34; 9:31; 11:14; Luke 9:1, 14, 43; 12:1, 22; 14:26, 27; 20:34
[71] Matt. 14:26; 16:21; 21:20; 26:8; Mk. 9:23; Jn. 18:5, 22
[72] Matt. 14:23; 24:1,3; Mk. 6:35; 7:17; 13:1; 14:12; Luke 8:9; 11:1; Jn. 14:31
[73] Matt. 16:13; 17:20; Mk. 8:1, 4, 27
[74] Mk. 6:45; 10:23; 14:24; 16:20
[75] Matt. 11:1, 2; 14:36; Mk. 11:1; Luke 19:29
[76] Matt. 8:22

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were admitted.[77]

Jesus is the teacher. The ancient Greek word for teacher is διδάσκαλος. Out of the forty-eight instances of the word in the gospels, forty-one of them refer to Jesus. This word is derived from the verb διδάσκω "to teach. With regard to its use in the LXX Kittel writes, "God himself, the head of a house, or the righteous may do the teaching. As distinct from secular usage, where the aim is to develop talents, the OT relates teaching to the totality of the person."[78] In the Judaism of Jesus' time, "teaching signifies instruction in the law for the right ordering of the relation to God and neighbor."[79] Teaching offered a substantial place in the life of Christ.[80] He taught in the synagogue,[81] and in the temple.[82] He also taught crowds outside.[83] He taught outcasts,[84] and his closest disciples.[85]Teaching was so integral to Jesus' character that even when he was on his way to his death, he seized the opportunity to teach his disciples.[86] Jesus taught in the spirit of eschatology. The Kingdom of Heaven was at hand.[87] Through observing and participating in the healing ministry of Jesus, his disciples learned to meet people at their place of need. Forgiveness was instructed because it is integral to developing a relationship with God and with one another, which naturally points to the importance of community where healing and growth takes place. Jesus taught on the queue of certain events.[88] He also taught by occasional disputes,[89] and challenges.[90] Jesus instructed with observations,[91] questions,[92] and comments.[93]

[77] Mk. 14:3; Luke 8:1-3
[78] Kittel, Gerhard and Friedrich, Gerhard, Ed. *Ibid*. p. 161
[79] *Ibid*. p. 162
[80] Matt. 4:23; 9:25; 11:1
[81] Matt. 9:35
[82] Mk. 12:35
[83] Mk 4:1, 2; 6:6, 34; 10:1
[84] Mk. 2:13
[85] Mk. 8:31; 9:31
[86] Mk. 8:31; 9:31
[87] Matt. 4:17
[88] Mk. 8:14; 10:13-16; Luke 13:1; Matt. 26:50-56
[89] Mk. 10:41-45
[90] Mk. 2:18-22; 10:1-10; Matt. 17:24-27
[91] Mk. 4:1-10; 12:41-44
[92] Mk. 9:11-12, 38-41; Luke 11:1ff.
[93] Mk. 13:1-37

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Jesus instructed his disciples to reproduce the character of God in their life and conduct, and to conform to God's divine law.[94] With respect to Mark 8-10, Banks writes:

> "In all of this we see the forethought and preparation, flexibility and spontaneity, versatility and directness, instruction and participation, verbal and nonverbal character of the teaching and learning that occurred."[95]

Above all it must be remembered, "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."[96]

With the departure of Jesus and the arrival of Paul, the word disciple fell into disuse. All believers are disciples of Christ, but all disciples of Christ are "partners"[97] and "co-laborers"[98] with the Apostle Paul. Paul did not magnify himself. He always pointed to Christ.[99] Paul describes himself as a teacher.[100] He taught both formally and informally. He taught in synagogues,[101] in secular schools,[102] in private homes,[103] and even out in the open.[104] Paul's favored method of teaching, however, appears to be dialogue.[105]

As the world changes, educational institutions need to adapt to the new social climate. The number of full-time students is in decline. More students are living off campus. Some schools are closing or merging because of economic reasons. There are more immigrant students, and three-fifths of all students are over thirty. Fifty percent are married, and forty percent are single. Divorced and widowed make up the balance. Most students also work while

[94] Matt. 5:43-47
[95] Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 105
[96] Mk. 10:45, NIV
[97] 2 Cor. 8:23; Phm. 17
[98] Rom. 16:3, 9, 21; 1 Cor. 3:9; Phm. 24
[99] 1 Cor. 3:5-15
[100] 1 Tim. 2:7; 2 Tim. 1:11
[101] Acts 13:14-41; 17:1-4
[102] Acts 19:9
[103] Acts 16:31-34
[104] Acts 14:8-18
[105] Acts 20:7-12

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going to school.[106] Robert Banks discuses the fundamental flaws of the Western mindset regarding theological education and the widening gap between church and seminary.[107] Change is difficult and resistant, but change appears to be drastically needed.

GLOBALIZATION

Eight percent of the world's population lived in cities in 1908. In the year 2000, almost fifty percent of the world's population lived in cities, and by the year 2068 sixty-one percent of the population is projected to live in cities.[108] In 1993, Time magazine printed, "In the coming years, the fate of humanity will be decided in the [megacities]. Faster than ever before, the human world is becoming an urban world. Near the end of this decade, [humankind] will pass a demographic milestone: for the first time in history more people will live in and around cities than in rural areas."[109] Soon urban ministry will not be a specialized ministry; it will be the norm. "You only have to walk down the streets of any major city to encounter the world."[110] Without warning, the city has undertaken to dominate the globe. The realization of this phenomenon has galvanized a revival of research into urbanization and globalization by urbanologists, governments, nongovernmental organizations, corporations, and theologians. The statement of the Greek philosopher, Heraclitus (500 B.C.), that everything is in flux is certainly true for the cities of our urbanized world. People from all over the world are coming into and going out of the cities continually on a daily basis. The city is the center of economics, politics, entertainment, education, the media , and technology. All these and other elements interconnect the cities of our world like never before. Not only is everything in a perpetual state of change, but also everything is integrally interrelated. Not only may a change in one part of the city affect the entire city, but also a change in one city could theoretically initiate a chain-reaction that would impact the entire globe. Douglas Hall identifies the interrelated complexity of the urban world when he states, "The city networks everything that is in it, for good or for evil."[111] The

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106 Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 5

107 *Ibid*. p. 10-11

108 Davey, Andrew. Urban Christianity And Global Order. Peabody, MA 01961: Hendrickson Publishers, Inc. 2002, p. 5

109 Van Engen, Charles. *God So Loved the City*. Monrovia, CA: MARC 1996, p. x

110 Davey, Andrew. *Ibid*. p. 3

111 Villafane, Eldin. *Seek The Peace Of The City*. Grand Rapids, Michigan 49503: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company 1995, p. 98

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sudden transformation from *gemeinschaft* to *gesellschaft* produces an *anomie* that conditions many people to be receptive to the gospel of Jesus Christ. If the gospel is successful in the city, it will become one of the commodities to be exported along with all the other elements in the urban context. This is a tremendous missionary opportunity. Both Douglas Hall and Efrain Agosto have noted the Pauline strategy to target cities for missionary activity.[112] Ray Bakke writes, "Paul penetrated the cities; the gospel did the traveling. The city has always functioned like the woofer and tweeter of an amplifying system."[113] The Pauline strategy is no less effective today. Missionary-minded evangelicals would do well to employ this method. Ray Bakke further writes, "The frontier of world mission is no longer geographically distant; it is culturally distant but geographically right next door."[114] Western missionary strategies have been coined, "from everywhere to everywhere." The sad fact is that not only has this concept resulted in the neglect of the city, it has also influenced Christians to shun the city.

The prophet Jeremiah sets the framework for effective urban ministry:

> "This is what the LORD Almighty, the God of Israel, says to all those I carried into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon: 'Build houses and settle down; plant gardens and eat what they produce. Marry and have sons and daughters; find wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, so that they too may have sons and daughters. Increase in number there; do not decrease. Also, seek the peace and prosperity of the city to which I have carried you into exile. Pray to the LORD for it, because if it prospers, you too will prosper.'"[115]

This passage demonstrates that God sent his chosen people into the oppressive city to "seek the peace and prosperity of the city." Furthermore, the peace and prosperity of the people of God depend on the peace and prosperity of the city. Robert Linthicum observes that the promises made in this passage are both urban and conditional.[116] He also states that verse 7 is the John 3:16 of urban Christians.[117] The city is the context of God's redemptive activity. Because God takes the city seriously as the context of our life, it is important that the Christian takes it seriously as the context of ministry. Obviously the city is important to God. Our theological and biblical perspective of the city will greatly influence our reasons and methodology for urban ministry. In the above quoted passage note that God's people are sent

[112] Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. 98, 104-105
[113] Bakke, Ray. *A Theology As Big As The City*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press 1997, p. 157
[114] Bakke, Ray. *Ibid*. p, 73
[115] Jer. 29:4-7, NIV
[116] Linthicum, Robert C. *City of God City of Satan*. Grand Rapids, Michigan: Zondervan Publishing House 1991, p. 17
[117] *Ibid*.

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into the city by divine volition. God also instructs them to build houses and settle down, to raise families for generations to come, and to participate in the economy. As previously stated, their well-being depends on the well-being of the city. In ministry, the church needs to respond to God's call into the city.[118] Urban missionaries should settle down in the city and raise their families there meaning that they should plan to be there for the long haul. Ray Bakke has noted, "The presence of godly people is beneficial for the salvation of places."[119] Mark Gornik admonishes to be faithful in small things persistently focusing on the present, but consistently over time.[120] Robert Linthicum expounds on Jeremiah 29:4-14 indicating that God sends his elect into the city not only to pray for it, but also because the presence of godly people in the city will save it from destruction.[121] Jeremiah has outlined a biblical theology for urban missiology. But with regard to the contemporary church, Ray Bakke comments: "80-90 percent of all major barriers to effective urban ministry are not in our cities--they are inside our churches."[122] He further criticizes the contemporary Christian approach of attempting to do God's work through the media while physically withdrawing from the city. The above passage also reveals that Jerusalem is not the only city that God is concerned about. In fact, both OT and NT revelations articulate God's concern for the entire world.[123]

The complex interrelated reality of globalism and urbanization necessitates more formally trained clergy. This is true on both a practical level and a political level. On the practical level, urban ministers need to understand the systemic realities of the interrelated urban complexities in order to be effective in ministry. Eldin Villafane has identified the political reasons:

> "Moreover, while we have always produced our leaders, they have never had the voice and the power in the larger church structure, let alone in society at large. A larger more complex populace will increasingly demand greater voice and opportunity in the existing denominational, ecclesiastical, and secular political institutions. This opportunity should be based on justice, leadership, and representational policies and not on whether we have seen the right degrees from right schools. But experience show that credentials still open doors even, sad to say, in the church world."[124]

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118 cf. Mic. 6:8-9

119 Bakke, Ray. *Ibid*. p. 4o

120 Gornik, Mark R. *To Live In Peace*. Grand Rapids, Michigan 2002: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 2002, p. xi

121 Linthicum, Robert C. *City of God City of Satan*. Grand Rapids, Michigan: Zondervan Publishing House 1991, p.157, cf. Gen. 18:16-32

122 Bakke, Ray. Ibid. p. 20

123 Gen. 12:1-3; Isa. 2:1-5; Jn. 3:16; Matt. 28:18-20; etc.

124 Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. p. 121

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The trajectory of traditional theological education and the flow of the city's needs travel in two different directions. Theological institutions are caught in the middle when they are confronted with the different and conflicting sociopolitical expectations from the secular academy, the church, and the urban environment. Carolyn Tennant's comment is quite challenging:

> "Our academic world can become too comfortable, too predictable: a kind of virtual shooting gallery in which we respond within a computer-generated space, acting as if it is reality. In this environment, we can trip over things, jerk in response, move forward or backward. There's just one problem. It's not the real world."[125]

URBAN THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION

> "Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it: Love your neighbor as yourself. All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments."[126]

Theology is faith seeking understanding. It is the study of God and his relation to his creation. It embraces the saga of salvation history. And as Andrew Davey has stated, "Almost all theology must be urban."[127] Urban theology is faith seeking how to apply itself in an urban environment, the study of God in relation to the city, and how the drama of redemptive history unfolds in the sociopolitical urban reality. Robert Banks identifies theological education as a dimension of mission:

> "Orlando Costas begins with Kahler's well-known dictum that mission is 'the mother of theology.' Mission generates communities of faith and obedience that are ceaselessly searching for understanding, and influences the flow of understanding that shapes and renews the future of the church. Mission also stimulates theological education, as through the church institutions are created by the Spirit 'to teach the basic elements of the faith, to reflect on it critically and systematically, and to equip leaders for ministry.'"[128]

One of the foremost noted authorities on urban theological education, Dr. Eldin

[125] Villafane, Eldin, Bruce W. Jackson, Robert A. Evans and Alice Frazer Evans. *Transforming the City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company 2002, p. 193
[126] Matt. 22:37-40, NIV
[127] Davey, Andrew. *Ibid*. p. 11
[128] Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 131

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Villafane, writes: "If we are to effectively educate leaders for our urban scene, this contextual reality--multicultural and socioeconomic poor--must inform all aspects of the theological enterprise."[129]

Constituency

A philosophy of urban theological education must begin with constituency (Whom are we educating?). The elitist-focused constituency must be abandoned. The entire church must be involved in ministry and that means that the entire people of God need to be trained for ministry. When the divine call is received by an individual, the responsibility of the seminary is to assist that person to develop his/her gifts to the fullest of their potential regardless of race, ethnicity, gender, or age. In other words, people must be accepted as they are. Social or economic stature is not a gauge to measure criteria for the kingdom of God. It was not for Jesus or Paul so it should not be for twenty-first century Christians. The secular term "dysfunctional" should not be in the vocabulary of those in charge of admission. Robert Banks has noticed that,

> "While people may struggle with different weaknesses today and are perhaps more dysfunctional than earlier times, it is accepting Jesus' call and its consequences that is the issue, not the presence or absence of certain weaknesses. In any case, as we see with Peter, a person's gravest weakness is generally only the reverse of their actual or potential strength."[130]

The priesthood of all believers must be upheld. The changing demographic patterns in society are strongest in the cities. Urban theological education must be culturally and ethnically sensitive to this pluralistic paradigm shift that has taken the world by storm. Dr. Villafane has observed that if women were taken out of the urban equation, urban ministry would cease to exist[131] (probably because men refuse to leave their comfort zone and answer the call). So urban theological education must also be sensitive to gender issues. It should also be

[129] Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. p. 78
[130] Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 192-193

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nondenominational. The culturally and religiously pluralistic environment will create a rich atmosphere for sociological and theological reflection. The present proposal is primarily directed toward the Asian population in Lowell, particularly Cambodians. All the above principles are relevant for this cause, but it will also take significant prayer and special guidance by the Holy Spirit in order to team up with those who also are or are on the verge of this endeavor.

Contextualization

"And the word became flesh and pitched his tent among us..."[132]

An effective urban theological education program will "pitch its tent" among the community it serves. Theological education in the city cannot be done at a distance. This was God's way to minister redemption to the world, and it is the best way to minister redemption to the city. When Jesus became incarnate, the Scripture says that, "...he emptied himself."[133] The word used here for "emptied' is κενόω. In this context it means Jesus emptied himself of his power and privilege in order to contextualize his ministry. Jesus was not afraid to leave his comfort zone. One way to contextualize the program is employ indigenous leadership. The staff and faculty should reflect the community it serves. As previously mentioned, this will be difficult for the proposed program and it is hoped that Asian TA's working alongside professors of other ethnic origins will suffice until Asian professors can be located.

It is also necessary to employ the concept of the *locus theologicus*. The city is the place of God's redemptive activity, and one should look with enthusiastic expectation for the exciting

[131] Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. p. 80
[132] Jn. 1:14: καὶ ὁ λόγος σάρξ ἐγένετο καὶ ἐσκήνωσεν ἐν ἡμῖν

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God-sightings that will inevitability take place. Classes should be held in the community it serves as well as the administration. The present program under discussion will follow the CUME model of conducting classes in churches and parachurch organizations. It has been noted that this "pilgrim model" is instrumental in healing the biases and promoting reconciliation when students of ethnicities other than the dominant constituency attend classes in these communities.

A Biblical sound urban theological education program must have a good understanding and a strong commitment to the shalom of the city and all that it entails: kerygma, prayer, koinonia, and diakonia. The *kerygma* (Grk. κήρυγμα) or the proclamation of the gospel is the church's primary responsibility. It is the unique mark of the church. However, the proclamation should be a holistic proclamation, not just lip service. Jesus left his comfort zone in heaven and came to exhibit the *kerygma* with his life. The apostle Paul said that we are to have this same mindset.[134] This involves giving up your power, prestige, and privileges (κένωσις) so that God's power would rest upon you. It also embraces servanthood, humility, obedience, and contextualization (being all things to all people), and incarnational ministry in the city. But before you engage in sacrificial service, you must experience the power of the resurrection. The διακονία and λειτουργία are also important dialectical elements. The church manifests its witness and extends an invitation to others when it practices holistic ministry in the inner city. A genuine Christian community is the evidence that the gospel is true.[135] This is the most important apologetic.

Another important element of the *kerygma* is the proclamation of the gospel of *peace*.[136] The NT Greek word for peace (εἰρήνη) does not follow the normal ancient Greek usage. The NT authors employed this word with the classical Hebrew meaning of *shalom* (שָׁלוֹם). Linthicum explains the meaning of the word as, "Shalom is a state of wholeness and completeness possessed by a person or group that includes good health, prosperity, security, justice, and deep spiritual contentment."[137] *Shalom* denotes health and good life.[138] It also

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[133] Phil. 2:7
[134] Phil. 2:5-11
[135] Jn. 17:32
[136] Acts 10:36; Eph. 6:15
[137] Linthicum, Robert C. Ibid. p. 86

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carries the connotation of restoration of health,[139] absence of strife,[140] a blessing,[141] as the result of righteousness,[142] reconciliation,[143] prosperity and well-being.[144] The NT declares that peace has arrived with Jesus.[145] Christ imparts peace.[146] Christians are fitted with the gospel of peace.[147] It promotes unity,[148] and is a fruit of the Spirit.[149] The Christian promotes it in conjunction with holiness.[150]

Jesus said, "Blessed are the peacemakers."[151] Since the believer is instructed to "make every effort to do what leads to peace,"[152] it has implications for urban ministry. Jesus told his disciples: "When you enter a house, first say peace to this house. If a man of peace is there, your peace will rest on him."[153] By proclaiming the gospel of peace, not only will the words of eternal life enter the ears of the inner city, but by incarnational ministry the whole person is addressed as heartfelt needs are acknowledged and dealt with. And so the true meaning of *shalom* is fulfilled. This will lead to an authentic *koinonia* and the "peace of God that surpasses all knowledge."[154] As an agent of reconciliation, welfare, and justice, the urban community of faith works for the *diakonia* of *shalom* to broken and hurting people, and so become *true peacemakers*. The true Christian community will go beyond the walls of its building. The urban church is empowered as it engages in the *leitourgia* of confessing to, celebration of, and worship of the Prince of Peace. Mark Gornik writes, "Shalom is absent when a society is a collection of individuals all out to make their own way in the world.... Shalom comes when we, bodily creatures and not disembodied souls, shape the world with our labor and find fulfillment in so

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138 Ps. 38:3; Gen. 15:15
139 Dan. 10:19
140 1 Kgs. 4:25, MT- 5:4
141 Judges 19:20; 1 Sam. 25:6, 35
142 Isa. 32:17
143 Gen. 26:29; 2 Kgs. 5:12, MT- 26
144 Jer. 29:7
145 Lk. 1:79; 2:14
146 Mk. 5:34; Lk. 7:50; Jn. 20:19, 21, 26
147 Eph. 6:15
148 Eph. 4:3
149 Gal. 5:27
150 Heb. 12:14
151 Matt. 5:9
152 Rom. 14:19; cf. Heb. 12:14
153 Lk. 10:5, NIV
154 Phil. 4:7

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doing and delight in its results."[155] When the Prince of Peace instructed his disciples in urban ministry, he said, "And whatever **city** you enter, and they receive you, eat what is set before you: and heal those in it who are sick, and [then] say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.'"[156] The peace that Jesus gives is not the peace of the world[157].

"Prayer as a kingdom activity is not the last hope for the inner city; it is the beginning of hope. This at least was the conviction of Jeremiah."[158] Prayer is essential if the *shalom* of God is to be manifest in the city. "Seek the shalom of the city where I have deported you, and pray for it to the LORD because in its shalom there will be shalom for you" (Jer. 29:7, author's trans.).[159] Not only is the believer commanded by God to pray for the city, the result of that prayer is the shalom of the city. S.D. Gordon wrote, "God will do nothing but in answer to prayer...The greatest thing anyone can do for God and man is to pray...You can do more than pray *after* you have prayed, but you cannot do more than pray *until* you have prayed." We touch God in his reality by praying. This is a phenomenal resource that the church needs to utilize. This is especially important in the struggle against principalities and powers.[160] Jesus said, "And I will do whatever you ask in my name, so that the Son may bring glory to the Father. You may ask me for anything in my name, and I will do it."[161] The key to answered prayer is in the motive of the prayer: that the Son may bring glory to the Father. The Father is not glorified by an individualistic, consumer-style, materialistic Christianity. When urban redemption is taking place, the Father is glorified.[162] Prayer must be persistent and diligent undergirded by a faith that will not shrink back even in the face of powerful opposition.[163] "When justice is required, when the daily struggle for life seems overwhelming, Jesus teaches us to pray and not give up in the face of oppression."[164]

In the Lord's prayer,[165] under the first three elements the heavenly Father is acknowledged and addressed, a plea is made for his name to be revered as holy, and a cry is

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[155] Gornik, Mark R. *Ibid*. p.100-101, 119.
[156] Lk. 10:8-9, NASB
[157] Jn. 14:25-27
[158] Jer. 29:7; cf. Ps. 122; Gornik, Mark R. *Ibid*. p.119
[159]
((Jer. 29:7, MT): וּדְרְשׁוּ אֶת־שְׁלוֹם הָעִיר אֲשֶׁר הִגְלֵיתִי אֶתְכֶם שָׁמָּה וְהִתְפַּלְלוּ בַעֲדָהּ אֶל־יְהוָה כִּי בִשְׁלוֹמָהּ יִהְיֶה לָכֶם שָׁלוֹם׃ καὶ ζητήσατε εἰς εἰρήνην τῆς γῆς εἰς ἣν ἀπῴκισα ὑμᾶς ἐκεῖ καὶ προσεύξασθε περὶ αὐτῶν πρὸς κύριον ὅτι ἐν εἰρήνῃ αὐτῆς ἔσται εἰρήνη ὑμῖν (LXX: Jer. 36:7 = Jer. 29:7 MT).
[160] Eph. 6:10-20
[161] Jn. 14:13-14, NIV
[162] cf. Rev. 21:10-11
[163] Lk. 18:1-8
[164] Gornik, Mark R. *Ibid*. p. 119
[165] Matt. 6:9-13

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made for his kingdom and will to be established on earth. The last three elements embody three different theological camps: The liberals who work the social gospel (daily bread), the evangelicals who emphasize the spiritual aspects of the gospel (forgiveness of sins), and the liberationists who stress deliverance from social ills (deliver from the oppressor).[166] But the reality is that the true church should embrace all three elements and practice the genuine holistic gospel like Jesus and the apostles did. That is what we are praying for when we pray the Lord's prayer. Andrew Davey writes, "It ought not be possible to pray 'thy kingdom come' without appreciating the cost in terms of personal commitment."[167] The true church should be an agent of forgiveness, sustenance, and liberation.

Psalm 122 is an urban prayer. It encompasses the city's economy, security, government, and people. It is supplementary to Jeremiah 29:7.[168] God is sovereign and we can depend on him in prayer. The Scriptures teach that prayer is critical.[169] And we need to pray with the "burning patience" that Dr. Villafane describes.[170] Again Mark Gornik writes, "Prayer is the cry from the depths to God, a plea that the world be different, that our children not die before their time, that our homes be decent, and that our hearts be made new."[171] It is the responsibility of the church to fulfill both the great commission and the great commandment, to love its neighbor as itself in order that the *shalom* of God would pervade the city.

Another method of implementing shalom in the city is through God's design of authentic koinonia. The Apostle Paul uses this word thirteen times.[172] The author of Acts uses it once.[173] The author of Hebrews uses it once,[174] 1 John uses it three times.[175] A good example of authentic koinonia in the first century is found in Acts 5:1-16. . The Holy Spirit brings believers together and teaches them. This is the community or *koinonia* (Grk. κοινωνία) of the church. The word has the connotation of fellowship, sharing, participation, generosity, close relationship,

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[166] ῥῦσαι ἡμᾶς ἀπὸ τοῦ πονηροῦ: The preposition ἀπό is generally used in conjunction with a person, and so the article with πονηρός is likely identifying a personality, the evil one or the devil.
[167] Davey, Andrew *Ibid*. p. 96
[168] cf. Heb. 13:3; 1 Tim. 2:1-2
[169] Lk. 18:1
[170] Villafane, Eldin. Ibid. p.43-46
[171] Gornik, Mark R. *Ibid*. p. 119
[172] Rom. 15:26; 1 Cor. 1:9; 10:16 (=2x), 2 Cor. 6:14; 8:4; 9:13; 13:13; Gal. 2;9; Phil. 1:5; 2:1; 3:10; Phm. 6
[173] Acts 2:42
[174] Heb. 13:16

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communion, a common bond that unites. The community of the church should be an intentional healing community, offering support, aid, and fellowship to everyone, but especially marginalized people who need to be emotionally affirmed. The community of Jesus Christ should exhibit God's grace, be willing to endure suffering for the cause of Christ, display economic generosity, and share the gospel in word and in deed. Christ is the model for all these. Mark Gornik writes: "The community, in its corporate life, is called to embody an alternative order that stands as a sign of God's redemptive purposes in the world. Thus, 'community' is not merely a concept, as the term is used here, it points to the concrete social manifestation of the people of God."[176] Robert Linthicum adds: "Without our practice of community, we will not experience authentic Christianity."[177] The church's ultimate test of faithfulness is the quality of its living community. If it does not represent the kingdom of God, then it will be counterproductive. Church life should be built on the foundation of *koinonia*. Ronald J. Sider writes, "Paul's inference is that koinonia with Christ involves koinonia with all the members of the body of Christ."[178]

The word *diakonia* (διακονία) in the NT means to wait on tables, provide for physical sustenance or supervise meals.[179] It also has the connotation of the discharge of loving service.[180] It is used in conjunction with faith, love, and patience,[181] and it embodies all that edifies and the work of the saints.[182] Diakonia refers to the church as it ministers shalom to a broken world and hurting people. It refers to the agency of reconciliation, welfare and justice. Diakonia entails service. Jesus came not to be served but to serve, and his service was a sacrificial service. Philippians 2:5-11 indicates that the Christian is to have this same mindset. Examples of sacrificial diakonia are sacrifice of the body,[183] the sacrifice of self-interest,[184] the sacrifice of self,[185] and the supreme sacrifice of Jesus Christ.[186] Suffering is not something to be admired or sought out, but if it is necessary, the Christian is ready to render this diakonia to the Lord.

Other factors of contextualization should consider the reduction of bureaucratic elements,

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[175] 1 John 1:3, 6, 7
[176] Gornik, Mark R. *Ibid*. p.75
[177] Linthicum, Robert C. *Ibid*. p. 265
[178] Sider, Ronald. *Rich Christians in an Age of Hunger: Moving from Affluence to Generosity*. Dallas, TX: Word Publishing 1997, p.85
[179] Luke 10:40; Acts 6:1
[180] 1 Cor. 16:5
[181] Rev. 2:19
[182] Eph. 4:11-12
[183] Phil. 2:25-30
[184] Phil. 2:19-22
[185] Phil 2:17-18
[186] Phil. 2:5-11

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flexible class schedules and convenient locations for classes, and personal interface of staff and students. The servant-leadership model views other ministries as allies, not as competitors. The urban theological educational program is there to assist, equip and complement other ministries, not to threaten them in any way. If one ministry succeeds, it is a success for all the other ministries. If one ministry is hurting, all the others are in pain. In summary of this section, Bruce Jackson is quoted:

> "Theological educational programs must also be contextualized. A contextualized program of theological education concerns itself with more than communication of the gospel. It also considers the process by which one does theological reflection, the methods used in the program, the teacher, the course content, and the final purpose for the entire educational enterprise. Contextualization takes the issues and concerns of the constituents as its starting point for theological discourse."[187]

Curriculum

The curriculum of an urban theological education program must be immersed in the concept of shalom. It should be holistic in nature. It is not just a smorgasbord of courses and academic elements, but an integral process of critical reflection and integration. The curriculum should be so designed as to address the issue and concerns of the community as the community understands them. This means dialogue with the community. The goal of the curriculum is to produce nonconformists and servant-leaders. The purpose of such leaders is to build up the body of Christ by eliciting, equipping, and empowering its gifts. Eldin Villafane outlines three main objectives for a curriculum: "(1) to *form* pastors and teachers (and other leaders) among the people of God; (2) to *inform* them about the Scripture, tradition, reason, and experience in social cultural, and concrete historical contexts; so that (3) they may serve as agents of *transformation* in churches, denominations, and social communities in which God has placed them."[188]

Since this type of theological education by extension school enrolls mainly adults, the educational approach should be andragogical (or, *wissenschaft*) rather than pedagogical. There should be a strong emphasis on theology and Biblical studies but the curriculum should go

[187] Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. p. 124

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beyond (not omit) the classical disciplines of the academic encyclopedia to include praxis-focused ministry or action-reflection. One way of implementing this is to have a good mentored ministry or colloquia program. Another important element is to esteem the students and the teachers just as much a part of the curriculum as text books and course work, especially when life experiences are shared and the class as a whole reflects on them.

There should also be good social ethics courses so that urban ministers can adequately analyze the sociological matrix of the interrelated complexity and systemic reality of the urban environment. Research and writing courses will aid in the empowerment of individuals and consequently the community. But with regard to social ethics, it is important to have a good understanding of spirituality and public life. Spirituality has been defined as a way of living the faith, a religious style, a manner of approach to union with God, and the manner of living God's love poured into the believer's heart by the Holy Spirit.[189] Dr. Villafane defines spirituality as, "In the obedience to God, the following of Jesus in the power of the Spirit."[190] True spirituality is contemplative, wholistic, and apostolic. It moves people beyond the four walls of the church. Social spirituality is, "...the following of Jesus in the power of the Spirit in society."[191] Public ministry is defined as, "The ministry/service of shalom to 'strangers' or 'others' in society. A ministry that goes beyond the ministry to self, family, friends, or 'faithful' (church) as one seeks the shalom of the city."[192] This theme of spirituality and public life will be revisited in the discussion of principalities and powers. But before that engagement, a good understanding of justice will be explicated.

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[188] Villafane, Eldin. *Ibid*. p. 84
[189] Classroom discussion in SE 602, Dr. Villafane.
[190] *Ibid*.
[191] *Ibid*. cf. Micah 6:8-9a
[192] *Ibid*.

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Power and Justice

Power is related to the concept of justice. All power and authority is in God's hand.[193] Stephen C. Mott has identified three classifications of power: (1) exploitive power, (2) intervening power, (3) defensive power.[194] Connecting power with justice, Mott writes, "The reign of God is arriving with its final blessings as God intervenes on behalf of the poor (and in the Lucan form, with woes for their oppressors)...In love one does not assert certain prerogatives of defensive power. Instead, one trusts the intervening power of God, who will not rest with the exploitive power of humankind."[195] Mott also identifies three types of justice: (1) distributive justice, (2) retributive justice, (3) procedural justice.[196] Biblical justice is not merely a mitigation of suffering, but a deliverance from the power that causes it."[197] The priority of justice as a Biblical theme and a priority of God is explicitly articulated by the prophet Amos:

> "I hate, I despise your religious feasts; I cannot stand your assemblies. Even though you bring choice fellowship offerings, I will have no regard for them. Away with the noise of your songs! I will not listen to the music of your harps. But let justice roll down like a river, righteousness[198] like a never failing stream."[199]

This passage clarifies the fact that if the believer's life is not characterized by justice, his/her faith and worship is in vain. Jeremiah reinforces the concept that one's relationship with God is directly related to one's view and practice of justice. A knowledge of God that ignores or is apathetic to justice is empty and cerebral knowledge that has no root in the heart:

> "Does it make you a king[200] to have more and more cedar? Did not your father have food and drink? He did what was right and just, so all went well with him. He defended the cause of the poor and needy, and so all went well. Is that not what it means to know me? declares the LORD."[201]

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[193] Ps. 62:11; Rom. 13:1-2
[194] Mott, Stephen C. *A Christian Perspective on Political Thought*. New York: Oxford University Press 1993, p. 15ff.
[195] *Ibid*. p. 25
[196] Ibid. p. 76-77
[197] *Ibid*. p. 23
[198] Note here that "righteousness" is used in juxtaposition with "justice." The Hebrew word for righteousness here is צְדָקָה. It can be used with the sense of justice. The LXX employs the Greek word, δικαιοσύνη, which is used in the same manner as the Hebrew word. δικαιοσύνη is frequently used in the NT.
[199] Amos 5:21-24, NIV
[200] Note that government is responsible for justice (cf. Prov. 29:14; 31:8-9).
[201] Jer. 22:15-16, NI

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Jesus also promoted the continuity of God's priority of justice and the defense of the oppressed and powerless:

> "Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You give a tenth of your spices--mint, dill, and cummin. But you have neglected the more important matters of the law--**justice**, mercy, and faithfulness."[202]

Mott concludes by identifying the following elements as characteristic of Biblical justice:

> "...focus upon economic weakness, deliverance and restoration, the social priority of basic needs, participation in community, legal support of benefit rights as well as rights of protection and procedure, and continuity with the concept of love."[203]

Justice is an attribute of God. And so by the indicative that mandates the moral imperative as well as explicit commands, the life and practice of the believer should be characterized by justice as Robert Banks has so eloquently stated:

> "As foundational of human life, and as integral to the character of God, justice is an inherent dimension of *theologica* that should mark the whole process and content of theological education. Students are not just prepared for the work of justice; it should be the basis of all that is taught."[204]

Justice toward the poor and the public ministry of the church are inextricably interrelated. It entails the mission of the church: kerygma, koinonia, dakonia, and leitorgia. Jesus' primary mission was to preach the gospel of peace to the poor.[205] God appears to be biased toward the poor.[206] The fact is, God is an egalitarian. God is not partial; humankind is. That is the problem. God views everyone as equals. If people esteem some above others, God will side with those who are less esteemed. God is impartial. It is humankind's partiality for the rich and powerful that provokes God to favor the poor and powerless, and judge the rich oppressor.[207] The neo-conservative movement has produced a political climate in the United States that has indoctrinated Christians to believe that war is one of the tenets of faith, and to esteem the

[202] Matt. 23:23, NIV
[203] Mott, Stephen C. *Ibid*. p. 88
[204] Banks, Robert. *Ibid*. p. 30
[205] Luke 4:14:21
[206] 1 Cor. 1:26-31
[207] cf. Ezk. 16:49-50

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Scripturally mandated ministry to the poor as a demonic left-wing issue. But just as Jim Wallis has stated, "You know poverty is not a left-wing issue; it's a Christian issue, and it's time for us all to recognize that."[208]

According to Isaiah 58:1-12, the believer will not be blessed until he implements justice, gives to the poor, worships and fasts. This is what the gospel embraces.[209] The believer should understand that God possesses all creation and we are mere stewards of what he allows us to have.[210] But generally speaking, the churches of America are materialistic, consumerist, individualistic, escapist,[211] indifferent, irrelevant, and impotent. Wallis is quite accurate when he writes, "Many middle-class people seem to want to underestimate or minimize the problem of material poverty. Or we want to blame poor people themselves for their predicament. The systemic causes of poverty and the moral indifference of the affluent are not popular subjects in mainstream America. But at a deeper level, a materialistic society fails to recognize its own spiritual poverty."[212] The difference between charity and justice should also be distinguished: "Charity is commendable; everyone should be charitable. But justice aims to create a social order in which if individuals choose not to be charitable, people still don't go hungry, unschooled, or sick without care...Faith-based charity provides crumbs from the table; faith-based justice offers a place at the table."[213] Charity has the potential to humiliate the disadvantaged, but justice empowers and restores dignity to the individual. One way to address the issue of poverty is to shun individualism and work for community. Justice is being faithful to the demands of relationship. Community is rooted in the trinity--the character of God. Poor people will usually help each other out and pull themselves together. A church can accomplish a

[208] Wallis, Jim. *Faith Works*. Berkeley, CA: Page Mill Press 2001, p. xii
[209] cf. Amos 2:6-7; 5:21-24
[210] Dt. 15:4-41; Mk. 14:7
[211] *Funga Mundi*: "Escape from the world"
[212] Wallis, Jim. *Ibid*. p. 76
[213] Ibid. p. xvii-xviii

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lot by developing a community that establishes relationships to empower the poor.

Principalities and Powers

The scandal of the church is the narrow view of public, which limits it to the self, family, friends, and the faithful. But as indicated above, public is all-inclusive. In dealing with the public ministry of the church, the spiritual aspects in all things should be viewed. For the Christian, spirituality starts at conversion. The cross is the key to breaking the grip of the power of darkness. The geography of the gospel should correspond with the geography of evil. The evil desires to keep the church in the margins so that wickedness may continue and prosper. Redemption comes through the power of the cross. Through the cross power is available for transformation. And the work of transformation is a participation in the reign of God.

Culture is the totality of the whole human product. Society is an aspect of culture that develops ways of relating. Externalization is the constant flow of the human product into society whether physical or mental (e. g. language system, economic system, political system, school, church, etc.). The human product then tends to take on a life of its own and affects the human being who produced it, and so then the human being becomes a product of what the race has produced (objectivation). Society is the product of the human and the human is the product of society. The fallen world and the sin-nature causes the propensity for institutions to fail and become corrupt. They are flawed, and so proceed to become skewed, corrupt, and demonic. The human is then galvanized to transform the corrupted product (internalization). This social construction of reality is the arena of our public life. The spiritual aspect of the phenomena involves God as redeemer in the work of transformation and the mystery of iniquity including

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the principalities and the powers.[214] Thomas H. McAlpine quotes Hendrikus Berkhof regarding this:

> "The principalities and powers, Berkhof argued, are the spiritual dimension of the social, cultural, economic and political structures that govern our existence. They have rebelled against God. God's reconciling work deals with them--and may include them. Our theology and practice need to take them into account."[215]

The urban missiologist, Robert Linthicum, has discerned territorial spirits, and has concluded that cities, nations, and institutions have a spiritual being assigned to them: "The practical system of a city is influenced with a spiritual essence, a 'soul' unimagined and unexplored inner depths. The angel of a city is the inner spirituality that broods over that city. And that spirituality has immense power--either for good or for ill."[216] Linthicum's conclusions are not without Scriptural warrant. It was revealed to Daniel by an angel that he was delayed in bringing a message to him because he was involved in an altercation with the demonic spirit of Persia. But then the angel of the Israelites, Michael, came to assist the angel.[217] This necessitates the importance of prayer and fasting and putting on the whole armor of God.[218] Christians need to conscientiously confront these principalities and powers. McAlpine also discusses the concept of "collective possession" using Nazi Germany as an example.[219] This is rather alarming in view of the idolatrous nature of the United States and all its gods of materialism, consumerism, individualism, and escapism. Walter Wink offers a statement of what America's angel might like to say to the people of the United States:

> "My light of hope is still raised over your shore, and more people than ever in history are fleeting to me, yet my hands are tied by the dark power created by your worship of things. Wealth is your real god, and all your gravest sins have been committed for it. You bought and sold slaves and killed my native peoples for wealth, you intervene in foreign lands for wealth, you sacrifice your own children in wars fought for control of world

[214] 2 Thess. 2:7; Eph. 6:10-18; 2 Cor. 10:3-5; Col. 2:13-15
[215] McAlpine, Thomas H. *Facing the Powers*. Eugene, Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers 2003, p. 3
[216] Linthicum, Robert. *Ibid.* p. 75
[217] Dan. 10:12-13; cf. Dt. 32:8-9; 2 Kgs. 19:35-36; Rev. 1:20ff.
[218] Eph. 6:10-20
[219] McAlpine, Thomas H. *Ibid*. p. 20

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> markets, and you demonize Communists because they challenge your system of wealth... I need help. I cannot get through to my own people. They listen only to their idols. You must come to my aid, even as I have come to yours, now that you have become open to me."[220]

In addition to praying and fasting and all the other Biblical instructions for spiritual warfare, another way to confront the principalities and powers, and to bring healing to communities is through community organizing.

Community Organizing

Community organizing can be used as an avenue for participation in the reign of God. Robert Linthicum defines community organizing as, "Community organization is that process by which the people in an urban community organize themselves to deal with the essential forces that are exploiting their community and causing them to be powerless."[221] Community organizing is based on the concept that the people who are directly affected by the problem are the ones best able to address it. This is very similar to H. R. Niebuhr's view of justice as paraphrased by Karen Lebacqz,"...only those who suffer injustice and are involved in the struggle for justice can know what justice is. Justice has become not merely structural, but systemic."[222] Community organizing is a tool to attribute political power to the disenfranchised and the powerless. Sider has observed, "When we want to effect change, we almost always contact people with influence, prestige, and power. When God wants to save the world, he often selects slaves, prostitutes, and sundry other disadvantaged folks."[223] Community organizing is not the church, but it can be a convenient place for evangelism. It is about the healing of communities, the correcting of wrongs, and the work for justice.[224] Tremendous power can be

[220] McAlpine, Thomas H. *Ibid*. p. 22; originally written by Wink in 1986.
[221] Linthicum, Robert C. *Empowering the Poor*. Monrovia, CA: Marc Books 1991, p. 43
[222] Lebacqz, Karen. *Six Theories of Justice*. Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Publishing House 1986, p. 117
[223] Sider, Ronald J. *Ibid*. p. 52
[224] cf. Micah 5:6

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generated when people act collectively. There is power in numbers and united we stand; divided we fall. Linthicum's definition of community corresponds with his view of organizing: "Community is a group of people with a continuing experience, tradition and history, who support and challenge each other to act powerfully, both individually and collectively, to affirm, defend and advance their values and self-interests."[225] Community organizations have the ability to become powerful agents to address the social ills of society and to hold public officials accountable. Community organizations transform communities and transformation is directly related to redemption and redemption is part of the public ministry of the church. It was noted earlier that the Lower Highland neighborhood in Lowell has a community organization. It would be worthwhile for some of the Asian members of the community to get involved in order to bring about change. A curriculum that teaches the principle of community organization would be instrumental for the transformation of the community.

It would also be beneficial, in light of the community analysis, to have some type of course that gave an overview of the political process (perhaps part of social ethics) so that the Asian residents would be better equipped to engage in social action and understand the importance of voting. Another suggestion is some type of basic economic course so that the Asian immigrants would better understand the system and work for change. Other needs are courses pertaining to family counseling, youth ministry, English as a second language. A good curriculum should include everything discussed in this section both in theory and practice.

CONCLUSION

Traditional theological education is increasingly losing its relevancy; therefore, a more contextualized approach is needed. This brief proposal for an urban theological education for church leadership in the city of Lowell has offered two models to study and evaluate along with

[225] Linthicum, Robert C. *Ibid*. p. 83

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the superb example of the organization to which the proposal is made. It contains an analysis of the targeted community and has surveyed some of the key features of urban theological education. In a project like this, a good theology of hope is essential. This hope is based on the eschatological spirit embracing the *parousia*. Time belongs to God, and God is working all things out according to his purpose. Bruce Jackson writes, "...there must be a sense of hope that knows the past and its impact on the present, but looks toward the future."[226] Wallis writes, "...faith makes hope possible. And hope is the single most important ingredient for changing the world."[227] In fact, we are not at liberty to stop praying or to cease from works of mercy. Indeed, "we are captives of hope."[228] This program will be dependent on the blessing of the community, affordable tuition, the *homogeneous principle* implemented among staff and faculty, partnership and collaboration with churches, parachurch organizations, and other educational institutions. If this occurs then, the realization of this program could prove to be significantly instrumental in participating in the earthly expansion of the reign of God.

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[226] Villafane, Eldin. Ibid. p. 137
[227] Wallis, Jim. *Ibid*. p. 1
[228] Wallis, Jim. *Ibid*. p. 1

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APPENDIX

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VISIONS FOR SPRINGFIELD
STATEMENT OF PURPOSE
2000

The ***purpose*** of Visions for Springfield is to understand and help nurture the vitality of the church in the context of the broader urban community of Springfield, Massachusetts.

*The **context** of our ministry: the church in the context of the broader urban community of Springfield, Massachusetts.*

The church is God's chosen instrument to bring His Life and Presence into our communities, and is God's appointed means of spreading the Gospel of Jesus Christ. Therefore the church is our priority as well. We focus our work in Springfield because cities are strategic in expanding God's Kingdom in the entire Valley, and because this is the city to which God has called us. Here we seek to minister to all people, and to help the churches as they reach out to their neighbors.

*The **action** of our ministry: to understand and help nurture.*

Through personal networks, research, consulting, prayer, and a variety of ministries and services, we seek to understand the vitality of the urban church. Our corporate understanding grows as we listen to those active in urban ministry. We offer help when we are asked, preferring not to act on our own, but to help nurture what is already bearing fruit. When asked by urban church leaders, we gladly provide resources and services.

*The **goal** of our ministry: the vitality of the church*

The spiritual vitality of the church is the city's and the region's greatest resource. Vital churches are both spiritually and socially relevant, meeting a full spectrum of human need. Vital churches are characterized by obedience to God's purpose, by service to the world as servants and witnesses, by working to extend God's reign and build up the Body of Christ, and by their desire to glorify the Name of Jesus. Vision for Springfield will apply ministry resources to enhance and encourage the vitality of the church.

PRINCIPLES OF MINISTRY

We seek the Lord's leading and timing in making decisions

Our desire is that the Lord directs our steps. We therefore base our ministry decisions on the essentials of Scripture, prayer, and seeking God's direction through biblical reflection. As we pray and think about our decisions, we wait until the time is ripe and the Lord says to move ahead.

We seek long-term results

We design our ministries to produce long-term results rather than the sometimes more gratifying immediate - or short-term results. We seek to understand how to be productive and avoid the pitfalls of counter-productive efforts. In order to accomplish this, we move slowly and carefully in developing new ministries and in making important decisions, basing our activities on proven ministry models and on research. By making ourselves accountable in our decision-making to

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other ministry leaders, our board, and our staff, we attempt to walk a discerning path.

We seek to build relationships with those with whom we serve

People reaching out to people is the essence of our ministry. We believe relationships are more important than institutions, programs, or policies. Therefore we are careful to treat people as people, not as objects of our theories or tactics. In all our efforts we seek to enhance the positive elements of people's ethnic identity and sense of community in Christ.

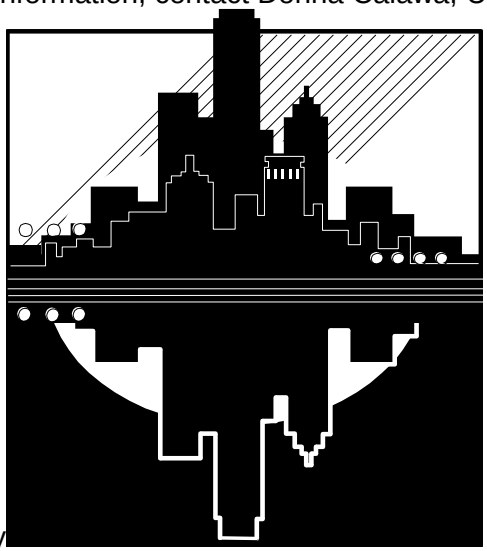
We seek to build the Kingdom of God in Greater Springfield

We focus on the unity of the whole Body of Christ in the city, rather than just an individual, group, church, or ministry (including our own). We foster the development of the whole church in whatever ways we can, sharing with others our plans and listening to theirs, designing our ministries so that we are not a threat to other groups, attempting to support all ministries of Christ in the city, participating in the strategic establishment of other ministries, and strengthening indigenous churches through training and development of pastoral leadership.

We use the resources that the Lord provides

We believe that God will provide the people and the resources to do His work. We do what we sense is best to do, not what we can "get money" to do. We are fiscally conservative yet fully trust in God's abundant gifts.

For more information, contact Donna Calawa, Urban



Missionary of Visions for Springfield at (413) 746-4012.

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Statement of Purpose and Principles of Ministry

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